

RELAPSE PREVENTION PLANNING

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Develop coping skills to use when experiencing high-risk situations and/or craving.
2. Develop a plan of action using the information gathered in previous exercises on relapse triggers and warning signs.
3. Take greater responsibility for recovery and increase the chances of success through planning.
4. Practice a program of recovery that includes regular attendance at recovery group meetings, working with a sponsor, and helping others in recovery.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE RELAPSE PRONENESS

- A Working Recovery Plan
- Avoiding Nicotine Relapse Triggers
- Building My Support Network
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Coping with Post-Acute Withdrawal (PAW)
- Coping with Stress
- Early Warning Signs of Mania/Hypomania
- Early Warning Signs of Relapse
- Getting Out of Myself
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Making Change Happen
- Personal Recovery Planning
- Physical and Emotional Self-Care
- Taking Daily Inventory
- Understanding Nonchemical Addictions
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- Using My Support Network
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Eating Disorders
- Gambling
- Opioid Dependence
- Peer Group Negativity
- Substance Abuse/Dependence
- Substance Intoxication/Withdrawal

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Relapse Prevention Planning” activity is useful for clients who are beginning in recovery or experiencing stresses that raise the risk of relapse. It provides a structured framework drawing on earlier exercises to anticipate relapse triggers and cues; plan coping or avoidance strategies; spot early warning signs of the relapse process; and identify resources and strategies to use to maintain recovery. For best results, have the client complete the exercises titled “Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues” and “Early Warning Signs of Relapse” before assigning this activity. Follow-up may include having the client present his or her plan to the therapist, treatment group, and program sponsor; keep a log or journal on plan compliance; and report back on the outcomes of his/her uses of the strategies planned.

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Specific Plan to Avoid Drinking or Using

Review progress, ask others what growth they see

Attend meetings; contact sponsor; meditate

[illegible]

Work with your therapist, your group, or others to rehearse how you'll handle these situations.

4. Recovery is not a solo process, which is why people who try to quit without help from others usually relapse. Who will you contact for support and assistance? List six people here.

Name

Phone Number

5. Emergency planning: your relapse prevention plan should include what you will do if you encounter a sudden crisis, a stressful situation that triggers a strong urge to use or drink. This plan should be simple and should be something you can start doing right away. If you encounter an unexpected life event that puts you at risk, your plan of action will be:

6. You should also have some general-purpose strategies ready for use if you encounter relapse triggers or warning signs you hadn't specifically planned for. List five general-purpose strategies to stay clean and sober here.

7. Changing your routine is important in staying sober. How will you begin and end each day?

8. Your plan should include support groups—Alcoholics Anonymous, Narcotics Anonymous, Gamblers Anonymous, and so on. List meetings you will commit yourself to attend regularly.

Name of Group

Day and Time

Location

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9. Do you foresee any obstacles/barriers to implementing this plan? If so, what are they?

10. What will you do about these roadblocks to your recovery or any others you experience?

11. If your plan isn't enough and you relapse, what will you do to get back on track in your recovery?

12. Are there parts of this plan that you are already carrying out? What are they and how well are they working?

13. Now that you have your plan made, it's important to monitor your success in using it and correct it or add to it as needed. When and with whom will you make regular progress checks?

Person

When You Will Talk about Your Progress

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.